adversary to place malware on a computer, remotely and invisibly, which logs every key stroke, and records everything that appears on the screen. Such 'end-point vulnerabilities' render even the heaviest encryption pointless. They can be delivered via a mobile phone or through an internet connection (or by some other subtle and secret means). Snowden knows this. It is possible that someone with his technical skills could keep the stolen data secure on his own computers, at least for a time and if he does not switch them on. But that becomes ever less likely over time.

Security becomes outright impossible when the material is handled by a team of amateurs. How many people have access? Who has screened them? What are their vulnerabilities—financial and psychological? Does anyone check their bank accounts? Are any of them vulnerable to blackmail? Do they have any training in avoiding 'social-engineering' attacks (such as impersonation)? What about the use of force? What happens if someone becomes disillusioned and leaves the team? A shocking example of carelessness came when Greenwald's partner, David Miranda, was stopped while changing planes at London's Heathrow Airport in August. His luggage included a number of 'thumb' USB drives and electronic devices, carrying some of the Snowden trove (as well as, some reports say, a password, apparently written on a bit of paper). Any public official who carried secret data this way would be fired and then prosecuted. A similarly sackable offence would be sending secret material across international borders by a commercial courier company such as FedEx. The editor of the *Guardian*, Alan Rusbridger, admits that he did just this, and jokes about it on his Twitter profile.[64] (Mr Rusbridger's defenders say that the material was heavily encrypted and that both the sender and receiver were third parties; he may feel that this ruse is fail-safe but security professionals would not.)